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The Securitized Products Playbook
Networking Into a Fixed Income Desk

Nobody gets hired directly onto a securitized products desk out of college. You get hired into a fixed income sales & trading analyst program, you rotate, and then a desk decides it wants you. Everything below is built around that one fact. The desk is the prize; the program is the door; networking is how the door gets opened and how you get picked once you are inside.

WHAT SECURITIZED PRODUCTS ACTUALLY IS

The corner of fixed income that trades bonds backed by pools of loans rather than by a company or a government: agency MBS, non-agency RMBS, CMBS, ABS (autos, cards, student loans, aircraft, data centers) and CLOs. It sits inside FICC alongside rates, credit, munis and FX. It is a small-headcount, high-specialization corner of the floor — a large bank may run four to eight sub-desks with a handful of analysts across all of them. Small seat count is why relationships decide placement.

The Path, Stage by Stage

Stage	What actually happens	What you do
Stage 1 Before you apply	You need a reason for S&T over banking, and a reason for securitized over rates or credit. Learn bond math: price/yield, duration, spread, and what a tranche and a waterfall are.	Read a market wrap every morning. Be able to say what the 10-year did yesterday and why. That habit alone separates you from most applicants.
Stage 2 Sophomore year	S&T sophomore and insight programs open in the fall for the following summer, and they feed the junior-summer fast track. Diversity and early-ID programs open earliest.	Apply the week portals open. Run 5 cold emails and 2 calls a week to FICC alumni. Ask one question every time: what does your desk actually trade?
Stage 3 Junior-summer S&T internship	This is the real interview. Most banks rotate interns across three to four FICC desks over the summer and convert the ones desks ask for by name.	Request a securitized rotation in writing in week one. Get in early, stay late, take the coffee runs, and make one person on that desk your advocate.
Stage 4 Rotational analyst program	You start as a generalist FICC analyst. Typically three rotations of six to ten weeks, then a placement decision driven mostly by which desk heads want you.	Rank securitized first, but treat every rotation like the real one. Be useful in week one: runs, comps, cusip lookups, Bloomberg and Intex screens, unasked.
Stage 5 Landing the desk	Placement is a horse trade between desk heads. The desk that fights for you is the desk that already knows you.	Build one senior sponsor and two analyst allies on the securitized desk before decisions get made. Say clearly and repeatedly that this is the desk you want.
Stage 6 Your first year on	First-year analysts do the unglamorous work: pricing runs, inventory, marks, client axes, trade support. Trust is earned in months, not weeks.	Own the boring thing perfectly. Learn one sub-sector cold and become the person people ask about it. That is how you get a book.

WHAT ACTUALLY DECIDES PLACEMENT

Not your GPA and not your interview. Three things: a senior person on the desk who will spend capital on you; a specific, defensible reason you want that sub-desk and not the one next to it; and a reputation for doing the boring work fast and without errors.

Networking and the Desk Map

Securitized desks are small, so the same twenty people decide every seat. Networking here is not volume — it is picking the right people, asking for time instead of a job, and turning a few of them into someone who will argue for you in a room you are not in.

The Networking Engine

Move	Who	What you are actually asking for
Cold outreach	FICC analysts and associates one to five years out of your school.	Fifteen minutes on what the desk trades day to day. Never a job, never a referral, not on the first email.
The bump	The same person, five to seven days later, same thread.	One follow-up. If it goes quiet, circle back next semester — two bumps is where you become a nuisance.
The real question	Everyone, every time.	"What does your desk actually trade, and who else should I talk to?" The second half is how the list grows.
The conversion	The three who wrote back and were useful.	A relationship, not a contact. Update them twice a year with something specific you did. Three real ones beat thirty chats.
Inside the bank	Securitized desk heads and senior traders, once you are an intern or rotational analyst.	Twenty minutes at their desk, or a morning shadow before the open. Bring questions and stay out of the way.
The sponsor	One senior person on the desk you want.	Someone who says your name in the placement meeting. Everything above exists to produce this.

The Desk Map

Sub-desk	What it trades, and what the seat is like
Agency MBS	Fannie/Freddie/Ginnie pools, TBAs, spec pools, CMOs. Highest volume, most rates-driven, most liquid; the closest thing to a flow seat.
Non-agency RMBS	Non-QM, RPL/NPL, credit risk transfer. Credit work plus prepay modeling; smaller and more analytical.
CMBS	Office, retail, multifamily, single-asset deals. Property-level credit, and the most opinionated part of the market right now.
ABS	Autos, cards, student loans, equipment, aircraft, solar, data centers. Heavy new-issue calendar; the most relationship-driven seat.
CLOs	Tranches of leveraged loan pools. Sits between credit and securitized; fastest-growing, and most likely to be hiring.

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